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UNDER SUSPENSION Former BJP national spokesperson Nupur Sharma

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LINE OF OFFENCE

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The ruling BJP government at the Centre has had a week it would like to forget as it scrambled to put out the fires lit internationally in the Muslim world by the comments against the Prophet by some of its top leaders. The party has suspended national spokesperson Nupur Sharma and expelled the Delhi BJP's media cell chief Naveen Kumar Jindal, the two at the centre of the fiasco, calling them "fringe elements". On June 8, Delhi Police also filed an FIR against the two and a few others saying their social media posts could cause discord. A senior police official was quoted as clarifying that the FIR names people "across communities"

But even as the country's ambassadors in West Asia and other places fight to control the damage, in India, the BJP leadership has the onerous task of trying to placate its enraged core right-wing followers. Scientist and right-wing expositor Anand Ranganathan tweeted that "the Islamists only asked the BJP to bend but it chose to crawl". Others like Subramanian Swamy talked about the Modi government doing "*shastangam dandawat* before tiny Qatar". As the hashtag #SupportNupurSharma took wing, there was a flood of social media support for the suspended leader from the right-wing corner. A top BJP leader, though, defended the government's actions: "We are not at war with